

OpenBook · Forward Deployed Engineer — A Field
Manual for AI Deployment

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Preface

What This Book Is

Monday, 9:00 AM. You boot up.

The customer's security officer has emailed you a 27-item compliance questionnaire. Slack has 4 unread channels from the previous FDE; the latest message is "Why is the RAG recall dropping again?"

Your calendar shows: 11 AM customer VP sync, 13:00 model vendor cost review, 15:00 PoC review deck due to your manager.

You have one hour before you open the IDE.

What do you spend it on?

This is the kind of question this book answers.

Who It's For

Engineers already doing FDE work, or assigned FDE work without the title.

Concretely:

- 5+ years of engineering experience; can own an entire backend service
- Have run at least one customer PoC; have been stuck in production hand-off at least once
- Have called LLM APIs and shipped demos; haven't yet run an agent in a customer environment
- Comfortable reading OpenAPI specs, running SQL, reading distributed traces — no intermediaries needed

If you've never been customer-facing or never used an LLM API, do a few small projects first. This book doesn't teach the basics.

Who It's Not For

Not the audience	Why
Job-seekers deciding “should I become an FDE”	This book skips the career-judgment layer
Investors / policymakers	Too low-level; you want conclusions
Students / new grads	Missing prerequisites — won’ t be useful yet
Readers wanting LLM internals	No transformer / attention coverage

Three Promises

1. Every judgment call comes with a concrete scenario.

No “FDEs should value customer interviews.” Instead: “In your first week on a project, what to do, what not to do, and the 5 questions to ask in the first 3 customer meetings.”

2. Every technical choice gives you decision dimensions.

No “RAG beats fine-tuning” or vice versa. A matrix instead: data volume / update frequency / answer determinism / inference budget / compliance — judge for yourself.

3. Every chapter ends with an action checklist + an anti-pattern checklist.

The action checklist is what you can copy-do this week; the anti-pattern checklist is what real FDEs keep getting wrong.

Core Sources

The book leans heavily on:

- **A. Lawrence**, Forward Deployed Engineer Rule Book (Oct 2025)
- **Bob McGrew @ Y Combinator** (2025) — “Sell the outcome, not the product”
- **AWS GenAI Innovation Center** — public 45-day / 73% figures
- **Conikeec @ Substack**, The FDE Playbook
- **Nabeel Qureshi**, Reflections on Palantir

Full list in [bibliography.md](#).

How to Read It

The most useful way: **read it alongside a real FDE project.**

After each chapter, ask yourself:

1. Does my current project have this problem?

2. If yes, how did I handle it before?
3. How does the chapter' s approach differ from mine? Which is better?

End-to-end takes 6-7 hours; with a real project alongside, 2-3 weeks is probably more useful.

Feedback

GitHub Issues is the fastest channel. What I want most:

- **Counter-examples:** where the book' s recipe failed in your context
- **Real numbers:** your PoC conversion rate, customer NPS, week-one deliverables
- **Missing chapters:** critical engineering topics you think this book missed

The next edition will probably absorb the strongest signals.

Written May 2026.

Reading Guide

17 chapters, ~6-7 hours end to end. Two tracks running in parallel — pick the route that matches your FDE flavor.

Pick a Track

Track A: LLM-Application FDE (default)

Best for: FDEs at OpenAI / Anthropic / Cohere / Chinese model labs and downstream startups, shipping LLM applications in customer environments.

Path: Part I → Part II → **Part III** → Part V → **Part VI** → Part VII.

Highlights: Ch 6 stack matrix, Ch 7 RAG/FT/Agent decision tree, Ch 8 eval-driven development, Ch 14 agent deployment, Ch 15 MCP.

Time: ~5 hours.

Track B: Field-Delivery FDE (Palantir style)

Best for: FDEs at Palantir, AWS GenAI Innovation Center, AI consultancies — delivering data + software in customer environments.

Path: Part I → Part II → **Part IV** → Part V → Part VII.

Highlights: Ch 9 ontology / ETL, Ch 10 VPC deployment, Ch 11 SSO/SCIM/audit, Ch 12 PoC cut-over, Ch 16 handoff.

Time: ~4 hours.

Track C: Full Read (FDE leads, staff/principal cross-track)

Best for: FDE team leads, anyone doing internal training, FDEs who span both tracks.

Path: Part I straight through to Part VII.

Time: 6-7 hours.

Track D: Reference

Best for: A specific question — “how do I size hardware for private deployment?” , “how do I write PoC acceptance criteria?”

Use: Jump to appendices A–D and the relevant chapter.

Your question	Where to look
Choose a model / framework / vector DB	Appendix A, Appendix B
Write an eval set	Ch 8, Appendix C
Write an SOW / security questionnaire / risk register	Appendix D
Design an agent sandbox	Ch 14
Customer VPC deployment checklist	Ch 10

Difficulty Markers

- Direct — copy and apply
- Reflection — judge against your project
- Decision — org / commercial / compliance call

Part	Difficulty
I Foundations	☒
II Discovery	☒
III Scaffolding	☒
IV Data & Integration	☒
V PoC→Production	☒
VI Agent Era	☒
VII Handoff & Mastery	☒

Chapter Format

Opening — concrete scene or concrete counter-example

Body — 3-5 sections, each one engineering call

Key citations — a quote or two from Lawrence / McGrew / Conikeec / AWS

Action checklist — copy-do items for this week

Anti-pattern checklist — recurring failures real FDEs hit

If you’ re short on time, **read the action and anti-pattern checklists first.**

Recurring Concepts

Full glossary in [glossary.md](#). The load-bearing few:

Concept	One-liner
Sell the outcome	Sell results, not tools — McGrew’ s first law
Fix Forward	Fix it on-site, don’ t drag it back to HQ — Lawrence’ s principle
Eval-driven Ontology	Eval set first, code second — Ch 8’ s spine Palantir’ s core abstraction; Ch 9 gives an engineering view
Agent Toolset	The set of tools an agent can call — Ch 14’ s topic
MCP	Model Context Protocol — standard for connecting agents to enterprise tools — Ch 15
PoC Cut-over	The chasm from PoC to production — Ch 12
Handoff	The departure-day delivery move — Ch 16

Companion Resources

- **research/** — All research notes (7 docs, public)
- **Appendix D** — 12 ready-to-use templates for week one
- **GitHub Issues** — Counter-examples, real numbers, missing-chapter requests

Next: [Preface](#) → [Part I Intro](#)

Part 1: Foundations — The Shape of FDE Engineering — Intro

Applies to: Both tracks

What This Part Solves

To be written.

Chapters

See [SUMMARY.md](#).

Relation to Other Parts

To be written.

The FDE Workflow — A Real Week and a Real Quarter

To be written.

Opening

A concrete scene or counter-example.

Body

3-5 sections, one engineering call per section.

Key Citations

One or two quotes from Lawrence / McGrew / Conikeec / AWS.

Action Checklist

Items you can copy-do this week.

Anti-Pattern Checklist

Recurring failures real FDEs hit.

Three Laws — Sell Outcomes / Fix Forward / Eval-Driven

To be written.

Opening

A concrete scene or counter-example.

Body

3-5 sections, one engineering call per section.

Key Citations

One or two quotes from Lawrence / McGrew / Conikeec / AWS.

Action Checklist

Items you can copy-do this week.

Anti-Pattern Checklist

Recurring failures real FDEs hit.

Two FDE Modes — Data-Driven vs LLM-Driven

To be written.

Opening

A concrete scene or counter-example.

Body

3-5 sections, one engineering call per section.

Key Citations

One or two quotes from Lawrence / McGrew / Conikeec / AWS.

Action Checklist

Items you can copy-do this week.

Anti-Pattern Checklist

Recurring failures real FDEs hit.

Part 2: Discovery — Doing Requirements Like an Engineer — Intro

Applies to: Both tracks

What This Part Solves

To be written.

Chapters

See [SUMMARY.md](#).

Relation to Other Parts

To be written.

Discovery — Observe More Than You Ask

To be written.

Opening

A concrete scene or counter-example.

Body

3-5 sections, one engineering call per section.

Key Citations

One or two quotes from Lawrence / McGrew / Conikeec / AWS.

Action Checklist

Items you can copy-do this week.

Anti-Pattern Checklist

Recurring failures real FDEs hit.

From Requirements to Acceptance — Eval Set / Acceptance Criteria / SOW

To be written.

Opening

A concrete scene or counter-example.

Body

3-5 sections, one engineering call per section.

Key Citations

One or two quotes from Lawrence / McGrew / Conikeec / AWS.

Action Checklist

Items you can copy-do this week.

Anti-Pattern Checklist

Recurring failures real FDEs hit.

Part 3: Scaffolding — Six Weeks to a Running LLM Workflow — Intro

Applies to: LLM track

What This Part Solves

To be written.

Chapters

See [SUMMARY.md](#).

Relation to Other Parts

To be written.

Stack Decision Matrix — Models / Frameworks / Databases / Orchestration

To be written.

Opening

A concrete scene or counter-example.

Body

3-5 sections, one engineering call per section.

Key Citations

One or two quotes from Lawrence / McGrew / Conikeec / AWS.

Action Checklist

Items you can copy-do this week.

Anti-Pattern Checklist

Recurring failures real FDEs hit.

The Decision Tree — RAG / Fine-Tune / Prompting / Agent

To be written.

Opening

A concrete scene or counter-example.

Body

3-5 sections, one engineering call per section.

Key Citations

One or two quotes from Lawrence / McGrew / Conikeec / AWS.

Action Checklist

Items you can copy-do this week.

Anti-Pattern Checklist

Recurring failures real FDEs hit.

Eval Before Code — A Practical Guide

To be written.

Opening

A concrete scene or counter-example.

Body

3-5 sections, one engineering call per section.

Key Citations

One or two quotes from Lawrence / McGrew / Conikeec / AWS.

Action Checklist

Items you can copy-do this week.

Anti-Pattern Checklist

Recurring failures real FDEs hit.

Part 4: Data & Integration — Inside Real Customer Environments — Intro

Applies to: **Field-delivery track** (data / integration)

What This Part Solves

To be written.

Chapters

See [SUMMARY.md](#).

Relation to Other Parts

To be written.

The Customer Data Stack — Ontology / ETL / Real-Time Pipelines

To be written.

Opening

A concrete scene or counter-example.

Body

3-5 sections, one engineering call per section.

Key Citations

One or two quotes from Lawrence / McGrew / Conikeec / AWS.

Action Checklist

Items you can copy-do this week.

Anti-Pattern Checklist

Recurring failures real FDEs hit.

Working Inside Customer VPC / Private Deployment / Air-Gapped Sites

To be written.

Opening

A concrete scene or counter-example.

Body

3-5 sections, one engineering call per section.

Key Citations

One or two quotes from Lawrence / McGrew / Conikeec / AWS.

Action Checklist

Items you can copy-do this week.

Anti-Pattern Checklist

Recurring failures real FDEs hit.

Integrating with Legacy Systems — SSO / SCIM / API / Audit

To be written.

Opening

A concrete scene or counter-example.

Body

3-5 sections, one engineering call per section.

Key Citations

One or two quotes from Lawrence / McGrew / Conikeec / AWS.

Action Checklist

Items you can copy-do this week.

Anti-Pattern Checklist

Recurring failures real FDEs hit.

Part 5: PoC → Production — Crossing the Hardest Gap — Intro

Applies to: Both tracks

What This Part Solves

To be written.

Chapters

See [SUMMARY.md](#).

Relation to Other Parts

To be written.

PoC Cut-Over — What Crosses, What Stalls

To be written.

Opening

A concrete scene or counter-example.

Body

3-5 sections, one engineering call per section.

Key Citations

One or two quotes from Lawrence / McGrew / Conikeec / AWS.

Action Checklist

Items you can copy-do this week.

Anti-Pattern Checklist

Recurring failures real FDEs hit.

Observability / Cost / Canary / Rollback

To be written.

Opening

A concrete scene or counter-example.

Body

3-5 sections, one engineering call per section.

Key Citations

One or two quotes from Lawrence / McGrew / Conikeec / AWS.

Action Checklist

Items you can copy-do this week.

Anti-Pattern Checklist

Recurring failures real FDEs hit.

Part 6: The Agent Era — New Engineering Tasks for FDEs — Intro

Applies to: LLM track

What This Part Solves

To be written.

Chapters

See [SUMMARY.md](#).

Relation to Other Parts

To be written.

Deploying Agents in Customer Environments — Toolsets / Sandboxing / Recovery

To be written.

Opening

A concrete scene or counter-example.

Body

3-5 sections, one engineering call per section.

Key Citations

One or two quotes from Lawrence / McGrew / Conikeec / AWS.

Action Checklist

Items you can copy-do this week.

Anti-Pattern Checklist

Recurring failures real FDEs hit.

MCP and Enterprise Integration — Wiring Agents into Customer Tools

To be written.

Opening

A concrete scene or counter-example.

Body

3-5 sections, one engineering call per section.

Key Citations

One or two quotes from Lawrence / McGrew / Conikeec / AWS.

Action Checklist

Items you can copy-do this week.

Anti-Pattern Checklist

Recurring failures real FDEs hit.

Part 7: Handoff & Mastery — Intro

Applies to: Both tracks

What This Part Solves

To be written.

Chapters

See [SUMMARY.md](#).

Relation to Other Parts

To be written.

Handoff and Pattern Extraction — Turning One-Offs into Reusable Assets

To be written.

Opening

A concrete scene or counter-example.

Body

3-5 sections, one engineering call per section.

Key Citations

One or two quotes from Lawrence / McGrew / Conikeec / AWS.

Action Checklist

Items you can copy-do this week.

Anti-Pattern Checklist

Recurring failures real FDEs hit.

The T-Shaped FDE — Engineering Depth + Domain Depth

To be written.

Opening

A concrete scene or counter-example.

Body

3-5 sections, one engineering call per section.

Key Citations

One or two quotes from Lawrence / McGrew / Conikeec / AWS.

Action Checklist

Items you can copy-do this week.

Anti-Pattern Checklist

Recurring failures real FDEs hit.

Appendix A: FDE Stack Cheatsheet (2026 Edition)

Model APIs / orchestration frameworks / vector DBs / eval / observability / deployment — 3-5 candidates per category with selection dimensions.

To be written.

Appendix B: Model / Framework / Platform Comparison Matrices

Decision matrices by scenario: model selection, RAG framework comparison, agent framework comparison, vector DB comparison, eval-tool comparison.

To be written.

Appendix C: Eval Set Design Templates

A reproducible workflow from requirement to eval set: scenario sampling, labeling rules, automated + human evaluation, regression-set maintenance.

To be written.

Appendix D: Customer Kickoff Pack

— 12 Templates for Week One

Discovery agendas / PoC SOWs / security questionnaire responses / architecture diagram templates / risk registers / acceptance checklists / handoff checklists / runbook templates — 12 in total.

To be written.

Glossary

Alphabetical order. Source pages in [bibliography.md](#).

A

A. Lawrence — Author of Forward Deployed Engineer Rule Book (Oct 2025), the only standalone English book on FDE.

Agent (AI Agent) — An LLM application that plans, calls tools, and iterates autonomously. Subject of Part VI.

Agent Toolset — The set of tools (read/write/exec/network/...) an agent can call. Topic of Ch 14.

Anthropic — Maker of Claude.

AWS GenAI Innovation Center — Amazon’ s FDE-equivalent organization. Officially uses “Forward deployment engineering” ; published 45-day / 73% case figures.

B

Bob McGrew — Former Chief Research Officer at OpenAI. Origin of “Sell the outcome, not the product.”

C

Conikeec — Substack author of The FDE Playbook: A Practitioner’ s Field Manual.

Confluence — Atlassian’ s enterprise wiki. Almost always present in customer documentation; unavoidable in the Discovery phase.

D

Discovery — The first FDE phase: observe the customer’ s workflow, read existing systems, find the real problem. Topic of Part II.

Dual-Credential Training — Lawrence’ s concept: an FDE must hold both engineering credibility and domain credibility.

E

ETL (Extract-Transform-Load) — Classic data-pipeline operations. Topic of Ch 9.

Eval / Eval Set / Eval-driven — The evaluation set; the practice of writing the eval set before feature code. Spine of Ch 8.

Embedded Problem Solver — Lawrence’ s framing: an FDE is embedded inside the customer’ s problem.

F

FDE (Forward Deployed Engineer) — An engineer who lives at the customer site and ships AI/software into production. Subject of this book.

Fine-tuning — Continuing LLM training on customer-private data. A choice point in Ch 7.

Fix Forward — Lawrence’ s principle: solve on-site; do not drag the problem back to HQ.

Foundry — Palantir’ s flagship platform — ontology + data integration + application layer. Reference frame for Ch 9.

Forward Deployment Engineering — AWS’ s official term; equivalent to FDE elsewhere.

G

GTM (Go-To-Market) — How a product reaches customers.

H

Handoff — The move at FDE departure: returning the project to the customer’ s internal team. Topic of Ch 16.

I

Immersion Before Judgment — Lawrence’ s principle: live in the customer workflow before designing.

J

JD (Job Description) — A job posting.

L

LLM (Large Language Model) — Assumed to be familiar; the book assumes you can call APIs.

M

MCP (Model Context Protocol) ☒ — Anthropic-led open protocol standardizing how agents connect to external tools. Topic of Ch 15.

Morgan Stanley (MS) — OpenAI’ s public case study; source of the 6-8+4 cycle reference.

N

Nabeel Qureshi — Early Palantir; the most influential English-language interpreter of FDE.

O

Ontology ☒ — Formal modeling of customer business concepts (entities, properties, relationships, actions). Palantir’ s core abstraction; primary battlefield of the field-delivery FDE track. Topic of Ch 9.

Outcome (in “Sell the outcome”) — The customer’ s business result (revenue, cost, risk), as opposed to a feature, tool, or demo.

P

Palantir — Inventor of the FDE model.

PoC (Proof of Concept) — Concept verification. Ch 12 focuses on the PoC → production cut-over criteria.

Private Deployment / VPC Deployment — Customer-private / VPC deployment. Topic of Ch 10.

R

RAG (Retrieval-Augmented Generation) — A choice point in Ch 7.

Rule Book — Shorthand for Lawrence’ s Forward Deployed Engineer Rule Book.

S

SCIM (System for Cross-domain Identity Management) — Enterprise identity-sync standard. Topic of Ch 11.

Sell the outcome, not the product — Bob McGrew's first law. Topic of Ch 2.

SOW (Statement of Work) — Project scope document. Topic of Ch 5.

SSO (Single Sign-On) — Almost always required in customer compliance. Topic of Ch 11.

T

T-shaped Growth — Engineering depth + domain depth. Topic of Ch 17.

Trace / Tracing — Distributed tracing. Topic of Ch 13.

V

VPC (Virtual Private Cloud) — A common substrate for customer-private deployment.

Other

Anti-pattern — A common but harmful practice. End-of-chapter checklist in this book.

Action Checklist — Copy-do items for the week. End-of-chapter checklist in this book.

Bibliography

Full raw URL list and search-method log live in `../research/05-sources.md`.
This document re-orders sources by importance and type, leading with the few sources cited repeatedly throughout this book.

1. Most-Cited Core Sources

Books

#	Author / Title	Notes
1	A. Lawrence, <i>Forward Deployed Engineer Rule Book</i> , AI Circuit, Oct 2025. ISBN 9781970328097.	The only standalone English FDE book. Primary reference for Chapter 6.

Primary Interviews & Originals

#	Source	Title / Content
2	Bob McGrew × Y Combinator (2025)	YC interview — origin of “Sell the outcome, not the product”
3	AWS Generative AI Innovation Center site	Public 45-day / 73% / 22-partner figures
4	Palantir AI FDE official documentation	https://palantir.com/docs/foundry/ai-fde/overview

Long-Form Analyses

#	Author	Title
5	Conikeec (Substack)	The FDE Playbook: A Practitioner' s Field Manual
6	Fresh HQ AI / brgr.one	The FDE Playbook for AI (transcribed from McGrew' s YC interview)
7	Nabeel Qureshi	Reflections on Palantir (early-Palantir practice)

2. The May 4, 2026 Inflection Event

Source	Title
TechCrunch (2026-05-04)	Anthropic and OpenAI are both launching joint ventures for enterprise AI services
MarkTechPost (2026-05-20)	What is a Forward Deployed Engineer: The AI Role OpenAI, Anthropic, and Google Are Hiring in 2026
MindStudio	Palantir' s Forward Deployed Engineer Model Drove 640% Returns
Revolution in AI	The Palantir Model That Anthropic and OpenAI Are Now Copying
SuperML.dev	OpenAI and Anthropic Adopted the Palantir Playbook
LinkedIn Pulse	The FDE Wars Are Here: Anthropic and OpenAI Bet \$5.5 Billion
Forbes Tech Council (2025-12-29)	The Rise of the Forward Deployed Engineer

3. Industry Blogs & Playbooks

Source	Title
Jediteck	What is a Forward Deployed Engineer?
Kiadev	What Is a Forward Deployed Engineer (FDE)?
Oflight (Japan)	FDE: From Palantir' s Original Playbook to 2026 Guide
LinkedIn — Zamir Akimbekov (2025-11-04)	The FDE Playbook
fderole.com	Definitive Role Guide

4. Chinese-Language Community Sources (referenced for the China-edition Part VI)

Platform	Title
Zhihu	What is Palantir’ s “Forward Deployed Engineer” ?
Xueqiu	FDE — The Core Secret of the Palantir Model (Chinese rendition of Nabeel’ s view)
Tencent Cloud Dev Community 51CTO	Palantir Deep Dive 8: The FDE Toolbox Palantir Founding Engineer on FDE as the New PMF Paradigm in the Agent Era
Sohu 163.com	How Early Palantir Leaders Practiced FDE Is FDE Already Obsolete? Palantir’ s Next Super-Soldier: the Full-Stack Engineer
CSDN	AI Evolution: Palantir’ s FDE Decoded

5. FDE Rule Book — Identifiers

- **ISBN-13:** 9781970328097
- **ISBN-10:** 1970328096
- **Kindle ASIN:** B0FXSZW5HB
- **Author:** A. Lawrence
- **Publisher:** AI Circuit
- **Release:** October 2025
- **Citation form in this book:** Lawrence 2025, ch.X

As of May 2026, no public free version of this book has been located (searched: Anna’ s Archive / Z-Library / LibGen / GitHub / Substack / Medium / Notion / GitBook). Citations rely on Amazon “Look Inside” excerpts, publisher-page summaries, and third-party reviews.

6. Citation Conventions

In running text, citations use these short forms:

- Short citation: [Lawrence 2025] / [McGrew @ YC 2025] / [AWS GenAI site]
- Numeric citation: AWS publicly reports 45 days idea→production and 73% PoC conversion
- Chinese community citation: Zhihu / Xueqiu / Tencent Cloud Dev

Full URLs are not inlined in body text; they live in this file and in ../research/05-sources.md.
